

CMP-01 · COMPETENCY FRAMEWORKS

The PCI competency framework — overview

How the Institute states what a certified professional can do,
and what that statement is for

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PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.
AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

The Institute publishes a competency set for each of its three credentials — fourteen for PCL-AI, nineteen for PFL-AI, twenty-four for PML-AI. This document explains what those sets are, how each competency is written, how competency differs from knowledge and from membership standing, and how a candidate, an employer or an assessor uses the framework without misreading it.

— About this document

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The PCI competency framework — overview

In one paragraph. The Institute publishes a competency set for each of its three credentials — fourteen for PCL-AI, nineteen for PFL-AI, twenty-four for PML-AI. This document explains what those sets are, how each competency is written, how competency differs from knowledge and from membership standing, and how a candidate, an employer or an assessor uses the framework without misreading it. After reading it you should be able to take any competency in any of the three sets and say what it would take to demonstrate it, and what would only look like demonstrating it.

Who this is for. Candidates deciding which credential fits the work they actually do; employers writing role specifications, development plans and appraisal criteria; and reviewers and assessors who have to apply the same standard to two different people on two different projects.

— 1. The claim a competency framework has to survive

"Eight years' experience in project controls" is a claim about elapsed time in proximity to a discipline. It is compatible with eight years of running the same monthly report, and with eight years of rebuilding a failing forecast under challenge. Both people write the same line on a CV.

Three moments expose the difference, and all three are expensive:

- **Hiring.** An employer buys the second person and receives the first. The cost surfaces at the first month-end that goes badly.
- **Assessment.** A certification body has to distinguish them from a distance, using a sample of evidence, defensibly enough to withstand an appeal from whoever fails.
- **Dispute.** A number is challenged. The professional either can explain the basis of the number, the method chosen, the alternatives rejected and the sensitivity of the answer to each assumption — or cannot, and the number is replaced by whichever number the room prefers.

A competency framework is the instrument that separates the two people. It does that by stating capability as **decisions a person can make and defend**, not as topics a person has encountered.

— 2. What the framework is made of

Each PCI credential carries a published competency set. The sets live in the platform's certification catalogue, appear on each credential's public page, and are the authoritative statement of what the credential claims.

Credential	Full name	Category	Competencies
PCL-AI	PCI AI Project Controls Leader	Project Controls	14
PFL-AI	PCI AI Project Finance Leader	Project Finance	19
PML-AI	PCI Project Management Leader – AI	Project Management	24

Three consequences follow, and each of them is a rule.

The set is closed. If a capability is not in the set, the credential does not claim it. A holder of PCL-AI has not been assessed on capital structuring; a holder of PFL-AI has not been assessed on agile delivery. This is a feature. A credential that claims everything certifies nothing.

The set is not extensible locally. An employer may map its own framework onto ours, and should. It may not add a fifteenth PCL-AI competency and describe the result as the PCI framework. Changes to a published set are governance decisions, made once, centrally, and published — reviewed on a [\[CONFIRM: published review cycle for the competency sets\]](#) basis.

The counts are a statement of breadth, not of difficulty. Twenty-four is not harder than fourteen. PML-AI spans initiation to closure across predictive, agile and hybrid delivery, so its set is wide. PCL-AI cuts a narrower band deeper — governance, cost, schedule, earned value, forecasting, risk, commercial control and the AI layer over all of them. PFL-AI follows a transaction from appraisal to financial close and then into operations, and picks up the instruments that structure it. All three sit at the same credential level, which is **Leader**. Anyone reading the counts as a ranking has misread the framework in the first thirty seconds.

— 3. The anatomy of a competency statement

Every competency in this series is written in four parts. The structure is uniform so that two assessors reading the same competency reach the same question, and so that a candidate can see what evidence to gather without asking.

Definition. What the competency is, expressed in terms of the decisions it governs. Not "understands cost management" — a definition that cannot fail. Instead: what has to be decided, on what information, against what standard.

By level. What the competency looks like at foundation, practitioner, professional and leader. The scale, its verb grammar and its evidence expectations are defined once, in CMP-02 — Competency levels and how they are evidenced, and are not restated per competency.

Evidence. The named artefacts that would settle the question — a specific document, with a specific author, produced at a specific point in a project. "Relevant documentation" is not evidence; a dated estimate-at-completion note that names the method, the alternatives considered and the reason for the choice is evidence.

The false positive. What is routinely mistaken for the competency. This is in the structure deliberately. The dominant failure mode in competence assessment is not rejecting a capable person; it is accepting an incapable one who has been near capable work and can produce its artefacts. Someone who maintains a risk register is not thereby competent in risk; someone who runs a monthly earned value pack built by someone else is not thereby competent in earned value. Naming the look-alike is what makes the framework usable by an assessor who has fifteen minutes and a folder of documents.

— 4. Competency, knowledge, and the Body of Knowledge

Two different instruments, often confused.

The **Body of Knowledge** states what must be known: thirteen domains and sixty-one knowledge areas, grouped and weighted 40 % project accounting and finance, 40 % project management principles, 20 % AI knowledge and practical approach. PCB-02 — The thirteen domains at a glance and PCB-03 — Why 40/40/20 own that material; this series does not restate it.

The **competency set** states what must be able to be done. Knowledge is necessary and insufficient: a person can recite the four standard estimate-at-completion formulae and still be unable to choose between them in front of a project board, which is the only moment that matters.

The relationship to examination is worth stating precisely, because candidates infer more than is there. The published examination blueprint covers **PCL-AI only**; the domain weighting above is its spine. No examination blueprint exists yet for PFL-AI or PML-AI — no weightings, no item counts. The number of items in any PCI examination is not published anywhere, because it does not yet exist as a decision: it will be confirmed by a formal job-task analysis. The pass mark configured in the platform is 65 %, and the definitive standard will be set by a modified-Angoff standard-setting study. Scoring is criterion-referenced, not graded on a curve. EXB-01 and EXB-05 own the detail.

— 5. Three ladders, and why they are not one ladder

Readers routinely collapse these into a single hierarchy. They are independent, and CMP-02 sets out the relationships in full.

- **Competency level** — foundation, practitioner, professional, leader. A property of a competency held by a person, assessed one competency at a time. Most people sit at different levels across different competencies, and that is normal rather than a defect.
- **Credential level** — the level at which a credential is positioned. All three PCI credentials are recorded at **Leader**. Note that "professional" therefore does double duty in the vocabulary: it is a point on the competency scale and an everyday adjective. In this series the scale word is always written in the level context and never as a synonym for "qualified".
- **Membership grade** — Student Member (SPCI), Associate Member (APCI), Professional Member (MPCI), Fellow (FPCI). A standing within the Institute, not a measure of competence. Professional Member requires an active PCI certification; Fellow is by nomination. **Membership is not certification, and a grade never evidences a competency.**

— 6. Using the framework

As a candidate, before applying. Take the set for the credential you are considering. For each competency, write the single artefact you would hand an assessor, and the month you produced it. The competencies where you cannot name an artefact are your real preparation list. This is a routing exercise, not a score — see CMP-10 §6 on why a self-rating on its own tells you nothing.

As an employer, designing a role. Do not require the whole set at leader level; almost no role needs that, and the specification will filter out everyone you could afford. Select the subset the role actually decides on, set a level per competency, and write the evidence expectation into both the job description and the appraisal so the same words govern hiring and progression. A specification of the form "Forecasting and EAC — professional; Automation — foundation" is checkable. "Strong project controls background" is not.

As a manager, planning development. The useful unit is a gap statement with five fields: the competency, the current level, the target level, the artefact that would demonstrate the move, and the date by which that artefact will exist in the ordinary course of the work. If no such artefact will occur naturally, the development plan is a training wish and will not happen.

As an assessor. CMP-10 — Assessing competence owns evidence types, rubric construction, scoring rules and moderation.

— 7. What this framework is not

It is not a job description, and a competency set copied into a vacancy notice will read as one and mislead. It is not a training syllabus — the sequence in which capabilities are best learnt is not the sequence in which they are listed. It is not an organisational maturity model; it describes people, not functions. It is not a licence to practise, and nothing in it displaces a statutory registration that a jurisdiction requires.

And the status statement, which belongs here rather than in small print: PCI certification is developed with reference to ISO/IEC 17024 personnel-certification principles — the principles governing impartiality, defined competence, separation of training from assessment, and documented assessment decisions. **PCI is not accredited** by any ISO/IEC 17024 accreditation body. The framework claims to be a coherent, published, assessable statement of competence. It does not claim recognition it has not been granted.

— 8. How this goes wrong

The count is read as a ranking. Someone concludes PML-AI is "the hardest" because it has twenty-four competencies, chooses it over the credential matching their work, and is assessed on procurement and benefits realisation they have never touched. Breadth is not depth. Choose on the decisions you make in your job.

A local framework is published under the PCI name. An employer adds three competencies of its own, distributes the result internally as "the PCI competency framework", and two years later a candidate arrives at assessment expecting to be examined on the local additions. Map, do not merge; and label the mapping.

The person is levelled instead of the competency. "She's a practitioner" is not a framework statement. Real profiles are uneven: professional in cost management, foundation in automation. Averaging that into one word destroys exactly the information the framework exists to carry.

Evidence proves attendance, not capability. A training certificate shows a person was in a room. A tool licence shows the organisation bought software. A job title shows someone else's decision about headcount. None of them is evidence of a competency, and an assessor who accepts them has assessed nothing.

The false positive is skipped because it feels negative. It is the most load-bearing part of each competency. Deleting it in a summary — an internal one-pager, a slide — leaves a framework that accredits proximity to good work.

The framework becomes a disciplinary instrument. Used to justify a decision already taken, ratings stop tracking capability within a quarter, everybody learns to rate to the outcome, and the organisation loses its only reliable read on where its real capability gaps are.

Recency is not checked. A person who performed a competency to professional standard six years ago, on a project type that no longer exists in the business, is being credited for a capability that has not been exercised. CMP-02 §6 sets the currency expectation.

— 9. Checklist

Take this into the meeting where the framework is being applied.

- [] Which credential's set are we using — PCL-AI (14), PFL-AI (19) or PML-AI (24)?
- [] Is every competency we are discussing actually in that published set, or has something local crept in?
- [] For each competency in scope, have we set a **level**, not just named the competency?
- [] For each level we have set, can we name the **artefact** that would demonstrate it, its author and its date?
- [] Have we tested each piece of evidence against the competency's **false positive**?
- [] Are we levelling competencies rather than people?
- [] Has anyone in the room conflated the competency scale word "professional" with the membership grade Professional Member (MPCI)?
- [] Does the role specification require leader level on more competencies than the role actually decides?
- [] Is the evidence current, and if not, what would refresh it?
- [] If this is an assessment rather than a development conversation, are we following CMP-10?

— Related

- [CMP-02 – Competency levels and how they are evidenced](#) — the four-level scale, its verb grammar, and the two ladders it must not be confused with
- [CMP-03 – PCL-AI: the fourteen competencies](#) — the project controls set, competency by competency
- [CMP-04 – PFL-AI: the nineteen competencies](#) — the project finance set
- [CMP-05 – PML-AI: the twenty-four competencies](#) — the project management set
- [CMP-10 – Assessing competence – evidence, rubrics and moderation](#) — how a competency claim is actually tested
- [PCB-02 – The thirteen domains at a glance](#) — the knowledge side of the same standard

— Sources and standards

- PCI platform certification catalogue — the seeded competency sets for PCL-AI, PFL-AI and PML-AI ([backend/Data/MultiCert.cs](#)), verified August 2026. These are the authoritative lists; this series explains them and does not extend them.
- ISO/IEC 17024, Conformity assessment — general requirements for bodies operating certification of persons. Referenced for its principles — defined competence, impartiality, separ-

ation of training from assessment, documented decisions — described in our own words. No text is reproduced, and PCI is not accredited to it.

— Status and version

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